

Now Google's Got an Eye on You

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer

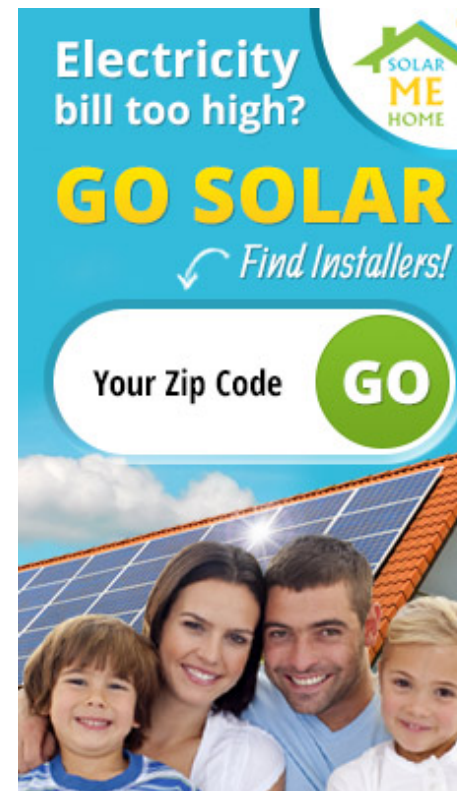


Google collects data. Not just data from what you do online via your searches, smartphones, emails and Google+ accounts, but now potentially all that real-world data hidden in your most private moments. Google-owned Nest Labs recently announced its intent to purchase Dropcam for a reported \$555 million. And with this latest acquisition, Google is one giant leap closer to total data nirvana.

For those unfamiliar with [Dropcam](http://bit.ly/1qB06ZZ) (<http://bit.ly/1qB06ZZ>), the company's flagship product is a WiFi-enabled security camera that you can access from anywhere in the world. Think of it as a globally accessible nanny cam.

Dropcam is not a strange choice for Nest Labs to acquire, as the intelligent home of the future should allow homeowners to remotely view inside their homes anywhere at any time. Dropcam makes that a reality, especially when paired with the data already being transmitted with Nest Lab's smart thermostat. The cornerstone feature of the Nest Labs thermostat is its learning algorithm where each device will learn its user's habits as it records, analyzes and predicts their activities within their homes.

These products seem designed for those looking to take full control of their homes. Having such control may be useful to the person who travels often and loses sleep worrying about his home. With a quick check, you can see that everything back home is still as it should be. But this technology may also make some believe that Google is further intruding into its customers' lives.



(<https://solarmehome.com/?cid=28806>)



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Public Reception of Google's Latest Acquisition

Now that the power of this technology is available to consumers, some have questioned exactly who else has access to that connection.

Marco Chiappetta, a contributing writer for Forbes [notes](http://onforb.es/1EvYKwx) (<http://onforb.es/1EvYKwx>), "I'm no technophobe and embrace technology every chance I get, but giving a single company as large, powerful, intelligent and aggressive as Google the means to see, hear, and track virtually every aspect of our lives gives me pause."

In a June 20, 2014 [blog post](http://bit.ly/1AWphQt) (<http://bit.ly/1AWphQt>), Nest Labs attempted to calm consumer apprehensions about potentially and unwittingly sharing their lives with an undisclosed number of interested parties. The blog post states specifically that, "like Nest customer data, Dropcam will come under Nest Lab's privacy policy, which explains that data won't be shared with anyone (including Google) without a customer's permission."

Four days later, a Wall Street Journal article revealed Nest Labs' plan did in fact include sharing some data with a limited group of partners, including Google. The news story ominously titled "Nest to Share User Information with Google for the First Time (<http://on.wsj.com/11chHS7>)" outlines the specifics of Nest Labs' plan to reveal customer data to a select group of third-party companies. This was assumingly declared in the subtext of Nest Labs' original blog post. If you refer back to that June 20 post, the addition of "without a customer's permission," starts reading like a smoking gun.

Questions remain as to exactly how mandatory this opt-in may be for owners of Nest Labs' products. Consider for a second the exact terms and conditions you quickly agreed to when you first opened iTunes. Remember each line of that [nearly 15,000 word document](http://bit.ly/1xsrejX) (<http://bit.ly/1xsrejX>)?

Shortly after Google acquired Nest Labs in January, Nest Labs co-founder Matt Rogers reminded both customers and potential customers that privacy still remains a priority. He states in a [blog post](http://bit.ly/1stcPxH) (<http://bit.ly/1stcPxH>), "Our privacy policy clearly limits the use of customer informa-

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tion to providing and improving Nest's products and services. We've always taken privacy seriously and this will not change."

What seems strange is Nest Labs' insistence on publicly distancing itself from Google, its new parent company. While it may be due to the increased public backlash to Google's compliance with [American spying initiatives \(http://wapo.st/1swOE2h\)](http://wapo.st/1swOE2h), Nest's insistence on publicly distancing itself from its new owner remains shrouded in mystery.



Utopia or Dystopia?

The sparkling clean and retro-future styling of the Jetsons' home was the idealized vision of living in the future. A robotic maid and self-cleaning appliances, a bed that implanted desirable dreams and a flying car instilled hope for a future where homeowners sat in the lap of luxury provided by advanced technologies.

But as we've barreled toward the future, a dissenting vision gained followers. George Orwell's seminal "1984" presented a dystopian view of a possible future society. One where history was constantly revised, unseen wars were fought beyond the walled off city, and government kept a watchful eye on its citizens through cameras installed in the home.

We've reached something of a crossroads where these two ideas of what the future might be have run headlong into what today actually is. On one hand, we have the simplicity and convenience of having more control over our homes when we aren't there. On the other, we will create a globally accessible connection point inside our homes. We must know that if we can access a live feed of our homes from anywhere in the world at any time, surely anyone with the where-withal and knowhow can do exactly the same.

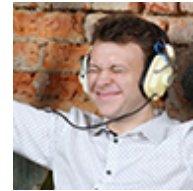
So where does the truth lie?

It's too soon to tell how Nest Labs, and by extension Google, intend to capitalize on having eyes and ears in the home, but it has already been revealed that Google maintains a supposedly [chummy relationship \(http://alj.am/145Goko\)](http://alj.am/145Goko) with the NSA. Unfortunately, this means that no privacy policy or public statement can be taken as proof positive that absolutely no one else is



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We all dream of finding the perfect home. We obsess over the number of bedrooms, being close to good schools, and



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Few things are permanent in this disposable culture of ours. But it's still hard to believe how quickly to-



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There is no more potent image of American prosperity than a sprawling tree-lined street filled with large single-family homes. In a word: suburbia - born...

watching. Also, since 2014 is well on its way to becoming a record year for the number of companies that have been hacked, we may never know who is watching us or our family at any given time.

Takeaway

Dropcam's technology can be incredibly useful to those needing to keep an eye on their home while away. The service, however controversial, is a step toward the future of intelligent home living. Apprehensions towards this product have really only risen now that Google's Nest Labs has acquired this technology. Can some of this fear be out of place due to Google's history with the NSA? Sure, absolutely. Unfortunately, we may never know who is on the other end of that WiFi enabled security camera silently surveying our most private moments.

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